Current Affairs 23-10-2026

Credit - Drishti Ias

India’s Accession to Southern Indian Ocean Fisheries Agreement

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Source: PIB

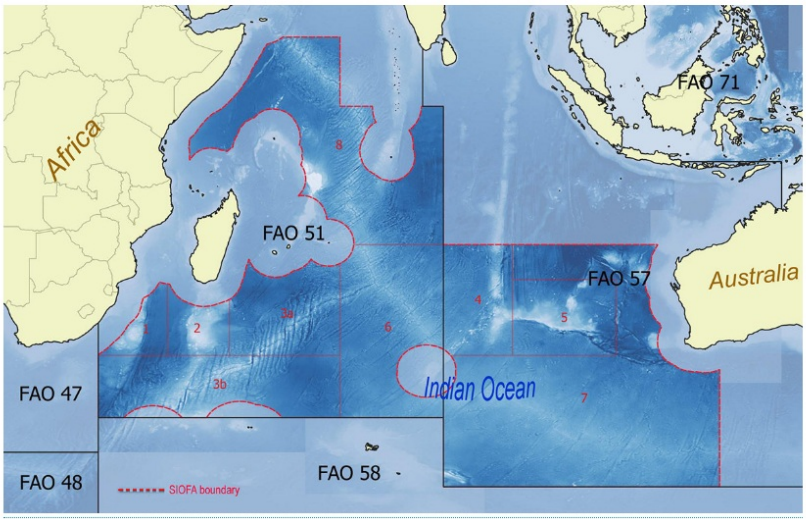
Why in News?

The Central Government approved **India's accession to the Southern Indian Ocean Fisheries Agreement (SIOFA).** This decision elevates India’s status from a Cooperating Non-Contracting Party (CNCP) to a **full Contracting Party,** marking a strategic milestone in India's role in global fisheries governance.

What is the Southern Indian Ocean Fisheries Agreement (SIOFA)?

- **About:** SIOFA is a **multilateral regional fisheries agreement** and Regional Fisheries Management Organisation (RFMO) aimed at ensuring the long-term conservation and sustainable use of fishery resources in the high seas of the **Southern Indian Ocean.**
- **Origin & Enforcement:** The agreement was adopted in **July 2006 at the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) headquarters in Rome** and entered into force in June 2012 and became fully operational in 2016.
  - It was established following the abolition of the **Indian Ocean Fisheries Commission (IOFC) in 1999.** SIOFA headquarters is located in Le Port, Reunion Island.
- **Core Mandate:** Its primary objective is to manage fishery resources on the high seas through multilateral cooperation, specifically taking into account the developmental needs of **developing States and Small-Island Developing States (SIDS)** bordering the area.
- **Species Coverage:** SIOFA actively manages and assesses resources including **fish, molluscs, crustaceans, and other sedentary species** .
- **Key Exclusions:** The agreement strictly **excludes highly migratory species (which are listed in Annex I of UNCLOS , such as tuna)** and **sedentary species subject to the fishery jurisdiction of coastal states** (as defined under **Article 77(4) of the 1982 UNCLOS**).
- **Conservation & Management Measures:** In 2016, SIOFA established robust regulatory measures, including **Vessel Monitoring Systems (VMS)** requirements, regulations on bottom fishing to protect **Vulnerable Marine Ecosystems (VMEs)** , and a stringent listing system to combat **Illegal, Unreported, and Unregulated (IUU) fishing** .

The SIOFA Area



Key Implications of India's Accession

- **Enhanced Decision-Making Power:** India has held Cooperating Non-Contracting Party (CNCP) status since 2022, which limited its role in decision-making. Accession grants India a full seat on the **Scientific Committee and the Compliance Committee, providing direct access to scientific data, research programs, and stock assessments.**
- **Expansion of the High-Seas Fleet:** Currently, Indian fishing vessels operate largely within 60 to 80 nautical miles of its **Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ)** .
  - Full membership allows Indian-flagged vessels and enterprises to undertake authorized commercial fishing in the vast SIOFA jurisdiction.
- **Security and Compliance:** It enables India to actively participate in the **High Seas Boarding and Inspection (HSBI) Scheme** adopted under SIOFA.
  - This strengthens national coastal security and helps prevent Illegal, Unreported, and Unregulated (IUU) fishing.
- **Alignment with National Policy:** The accession operationalizes the **Guidelines for High Sea Fisheries** issued by the Indian government in December 2025, which provided the policy framework to expand deep-sea fishing operations and boost the Blue Economy.
- **Geopolitical Counterbalance:** The **High Seas constitute roughly 65% of the global ocean** and are currently dominated by fleets from **China (21%)** , Taiwan, Japan, South Korea, and Spain. India's accession secures its legitimate rights and establishes a recognized presence to counterbalance foreign dominance in the Southern Indian Ocean.

Note: SIOFA is one of two major Regional Fisheries Management Organisations (RFMOs) in the Indian Ocean. The other is the Indian Ocean Tuna Commission (IOTC) **.**

- SIOFA differs from **IOTC** in its mandate, as SIOFA manages **non-highly migratory fish stocks** in the Southern Indian Ocean, while IOTC regulates highly migratory **tuna** and tuna-like species across the Indian Ocean. India has been a Contracting Party to IOTC since 1996.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Southern Indian Ocean Fisheries Agreement (SIOFA)?
SIOFA is a multilateral fisheries agreement adopted in 2006 and operational since 2012, aimed at conserving and sustainably managing fishery resources in the high seas of the Southern Indian Ocean.

2. What is the significance of India's accession to SIOFA?
It strengthens India's role in fisheries decision-making, scientific cooperation, high-seas fishing and efforts to combat Illegal, Unreported and Unregulated (IUU) fishing.

3. Which marine species fall under SIOFA's mandate?
SIOFA covers specified fish, molluscs, crustaceans and other sedentary species in its area of competence, excluding highly migratory species such as tuna.

4. How does SIOFA differ from the Indian Ocean Tuna Commission (IOTC)?
IOFA manages covered fishery resources in the Southern Indian Ocean high seas, while IOTC manages tuna and tuna-like species in the Indian Ocean. India has been an IOTC Contracting Party since 1996.

5. What is the role of UNCLOS in high-seas fisheries governance?
The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), 1982, establishes the international legal framework for ocean use, including high-seas freedoms, conservation obligations and coastal-state rights over resources within their maritime jurisdiction.

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. With reference to the 'Trans-Pacific Partnership', consider the following statements: (2016)

1. It is an agreement among all the Pacific Rim countries except China and Russia.
2. It is a strategic alliance for the purpose of maritime security only.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (d)

Q. With reference to 'Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation (IOR-ARC)', consider the following statements: (2015)

1. It was established very recently in response to incidents of piracy and accidents of oil spills.
2. It is an alliance meant for maritime security only.

Which of the statements given above is/ are correct?

(a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (d)

Mains

Q. With respect to the South China sea, maritime territorial disputes and rising tension affirm the need for safeguarding maritime security to ensure freedom of navigation and overflight throughout the region. In this context, discuss the bilateral issues between India and China. **(2014)**

Fair International Law: Navigating the Authoritarian Challenge

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For Prelims: 2026 Nobel Peace Prize , United Nations Charter , International Court of Justice , International Civil Aviation Organization , International Telecommunication Union , UNCLOS , High Seas Treaty , Montreal Protocol

For Mains: Multilateralism in a multipolar world is both a necessity and a challenge, International institutions, UN reforms, International law.

Source: TH

Why in News?

The awarding of the **2026 Nobel Peace Prize to South African jurist Navi Pillay** (former UN High Commissioner for Human Rights) has arrived at a critical geopolitical juncture. Amidst the ongoing wars in **Ukraine and West Asia ,** and the brazen violation of the **United Nations Charter** , international law is facing an existential crisis.

- However, the Nobel Committee’s recognition serves as a definitive global endorsement that a fair, rights-based international legal order remains indispensable in countering the aggressive rise of **"Authoritarian International Law."**

Summary

- International law is facing a crisis due to the rise of Authoritarian International Law, selective compliance by powerful states, rejection of international judicial rulings and the erosion of universal legal norms.
- A fair international legal order requires stronger multilateral institutions, equitable global representation, consistent enforcement of international law and India's leadership in promoting reformed multilateralism.

What is International Law?

- **Definition:** International law is the body of legal rules, norms, and standards that apply between sovereign states and other entities legally recognized as international actors.
- **Core Objective:** It seeks to maintain international peace and security, primarily codified by **Article 2(4) of the UN Charter** , which explicitly prohibits the threat or use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of any state.
- **Sources of Law:** As per **Article 38 of the International Court of Justice (ICJ) Statute** , International Law is derived from international conventions (treaties), international custom (state practice), general principles of law, and judicial decisions.
- **The Subject of Law:** The **post-WW II liberal order** fundamentally shifted international law to make the **individual** a subject of law, institutionalizing civil, political, and human rights.

Current Status

- **A "Discipline of Crisis":** As described by ICJ, international law is currently operating in a crisis mode, battered by **imperialistic designs and a precipitous decline** in human rights compliance.
- **The "Silent Efficacy":** While the breaches of the UN Charter regarding the "use of force" dominate media headlines, the vast majority of international law operates silently, seamlessly, and **with near-universal compliance every single day** . This "functional" international law sustains global interdependence across multiple domains:
  - **Global Connectivity:** The **International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO)** and the **International Telecommunication Union (ITU)** quietly coordinate thousands of daily cross-border flights and global internet/ **GPS** spectrums without dispute.
  - **Maritime & Global Commons:** **UNCLOS** peacefully regulates 90% of global shipping trade, complemented by the recent **High Seas Treaty (BBNJ)** and the **Outer Space Treaty** , which helps prevent the militarisation of space.
  - **Ecological Triumphs:** The **Montreal Protocol** stands as a historic success, actively healing the ozone layer through universally enforced phase-outs.
  - **Routine Transnational Governance:** Agencies like **WIPO** (patents/IP), **Universal Postal Union** (cross-border postal delivery), and the **WHO's International Health Regulations** manage daily global cooperation, even among bitter diplomatic rivals.

Click here to Read: India and International Law

How are States 'Retooling' International Law?

- **Weaponizing State Sovereignty:** While developing nations historically invoked sovereignty to resist colonialism, regimes now use it as an absolute shield against international scrutiny.
  - **China** routinely dismisses **UN OHCHR** reports regarding human rights in Xinjiang as "illegal interference in internal affairs."
  - Similarly, **Israel** systematically rejects resolutions and reports by UN Human Rights bodies regarding **Gaza and the West Bank** on the grounds of sovereign interference.
  - The US has withdrawn from international frameworks such as the **Paris Agreement and UNESCO,** illustrating how major powers can disengage from multilateral institutions when they conflict with domestic priorities.
- **Creating Pliant, Weak International Organizations (IOs):** Instead of joining IOs with independent regulatory or supranational authority (like the EU or early UN), authoritarian states prefer establishing forums where member-states retain absolute control and the IO cannot enforce accountability.
  - The **US-backed Board of Peace for Gaza** has raised concerns about creating alternative global mechanisms outside established UN structures. This, alongside the **US veto of a Gaza ceasefire resolution in June 2025** , highlights concerns about the selective use of multilateral institutions.
  - The **Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)** , prioritizes regime security and "non-interference" over human rights or democratic accountability, possessing no independent judicial body to hold its member states accountable.
- **Rejecting third-party adjudication:** There is a growing global backlash against independent international courts, with powerful states increasingly preferring opaque bilateral negotiations where they can exploit their military and economic advantages.
  - For instance, **China rejected the 2016 Permanent Court of Arbitration (PCA) ruling in favour of the Philippines** in the **South China Sea** dispute.
  - Similarly, the US has historically opposed the **International Criminal Court (ICC)** and imposed

economic sanctions in **2025 targeting ICC officials over investigations into alleged war crimes** , undermining the independence of international judicial institutions.

- **Securitization of Economic Law (Protectionism):** Major hegemonic powers are dismantling the **neoliberal economic consensus,** violating free-trade norms under the guise of "national security."
  - For instance, the **US blocking of appointments to the WTO's Appellate Body** , effectively paralyzing global trade dispute resolution.
  - Additionally, the **US Inflation Reduction Act (IRA) and CHIPS Act** , which offer massive domestic industrial subsidies that arguably violate WTO non-discrimination principles, are justified as **national security imperatives** against China.
- **"Rules-Based Order":** Democratic powers have contributed to this **retooling by replacing the binding term "International Law"** (which requires strict treaty compliance) with the politically ambiguous phrase **"Rules-Based Order."**
  - Western nations frequently invoke the **"rules-based order" to condemn Russia's invasion of Ukraine or China's maritime incursions,** but bypass the UN Security Council for their own military interventions (e.g., the **2003 Iraq War** or **NATO's intervention in Libya/Kosovo**).
  - This allows powerful nations to selectively apply rules to adversaries while exempting themselves.

Implications

Global

- **Erosion of *Jus Cogens* Norms:** Peremptory norms like the prohibition of genocide, territorial conquest, and war crimes are **being systematically undermined, creating a dangerous precedent for future state conduct.**
- **Credibility Deficit:** The selective application of international law where the Global North demands compliance from adversaries but **shields its allies is eroding the legitimacy of multilateral institutions** across the Global South.
- **Return of "Spheres of Influence":** A shift away from universal law invites a fragmented world order governed by neo-imperialism and raw military might.

India

- **The Maritime Security Dilemma:** India heavily relies on a universally respected **UNCLOS** to maintain a free and open **Indo-Pacific** and counter Chinese expansionism.
  - The weakening of international law directly threatens India's maritime security.
- **Trade and Economic Vulnerability:** As a rapidly growing developing economy, India requires a functional, rules-based multilateral trading system.
  - The paralysis of the **WTO Dispute Settlement Mechanism** leaves India vulnerable to unilateral protectionist tariffs from major powers.
- **Strategic Balancing:** India faces the complex task of navigating between a **hypocritical Western "rules-based order" and the Sino-Russian authoritarian** retooling, requiring New Delhi to **champion strict adherence to the UN Charter while protecting its strategic autonomy.**
- **Commitment to Multilateralism:** India has consistently advocated reforms in global institutions while upholding the existing international order, demonstrated through its contributions to **UN peacekeeping** , participation in international judicial bodies and acceptance of negotiated legal settlements.

Authoritarian International Law

Coined by legal scholars like Tom Ginsburg, Authoritarian International Law refers to a framework where **international legal norms are reinterpreted to prioritize regime survival, executive power, and state sovereignty over individual rights and democratic accountability.**

- **Contrast with Liberal Order:** The traditional liberal international law (established post-1945) views the individual as a subject of international law, emphasizing human dignity, fairness, and accountability.
  - Authoritarian international law, conversely, seeks to shield governments from external scrutiny.
- **Core Philosophy:** It views international law purely as a tool for **coordinating regime survival** , rejecting the idea that international law should protect civil liberties or hold executive power accountable.

What are the Challenges in Preserving a Fair International Law?

- **The Enforcement Deficit:** Unlike domestic law, international law lacks a global police force. Courts like the ICJ rely on the **UN Security Council (UNSC)** for enforcement, which is frequently paralyzed by the veto power of the P5 nations.
- **Populist Nationalism:** Ethno-nationalist regimes globally frame international law as **"foreign interference,"** attacking international institutions to appease domestic political constituencies.
- **Outdated Global Architecture:** The **Bretton Woods and UN systems** reflect the **geopolitical realities of 1945.**
  - The continued marginalization of Africa, Latin America, and India in global decision-making reduces the universal legitimacy of international law.
- **Normative Interaction vs. Immediate Compliance:** A major conceptual challenge is judging international law solely by immediate compliance.
  - Scholars like Harold Hongju Koh argue that its true efficacy lies in **Transnational Legal Processes** (the gradual internalization of global norms by domestic systems) which is currently being stunted by nationalist pushback.

What Measures are Needed to Preserve International Law?

- **Address the Enforcement Deficit (UNSC Reform):** Adopt the French-Mexican initiative demanding the P5 nations voluntarily suspend their veto power in cases of genocide, mass atrocities, and *jus cogens* violations.
  - Urgent structural reform of the UN Security Council is required, including the expansion of permanent membership (incorporating the G4).
  - When the UNSC is paralyzed, it aggressively invoke **Resolution 377 (Uniting for Peace)** in the UN General Assembly to recommend collective international action.
- **Reclaim the Legal Vocabulary:** Middle powers (like India and Brazil) must reject the Western-coined,

hypocritical **"Rules-Based Order"** and demand a return to strict, universally applied **"Binding International Law"** based on the UN Charter.

- **Bypass Sabotaged Courts:** Expand the **Multi-Party Interim Appeal Arbitration Arrangement (MPIA)** to ensure trade disputes are resolved legally despite the US blockade of the WTO Appellate Body.
  - Pass UNGA resolutions forbidding unilateral sanctions or political intimidation against ICC and ICJ judges.
- **Localize Enforcement via 'Universal Jurisdiction':** Empower domestic courts to prosecute severe international crimes (crimes against humanity) regardless of where they occurred, similar to **Germany's prosecution of Syrian war criminals** , ensuring accountability when global bodies are blocked.
- **Codify Laws for 'Grey Zone' Domains:** Draft binding multilateral treaties for emerging domains to prevent "might makes right" tactics.
  - This includes codifying cyber warfare limits (building on the **Tallinn Manual**) and updating the **1967 Outer Space Treaty** to ban anti-satellite (ASAT) weapons.
- **Reform the Global Financial Architecture:** Implement immediate quota reforms in the IMF and World Bank to give the Global South equitable voting rights, preventing the unilateral weaponization of global financial systems (like SWIFT) for economic coercion.
- **Leverage Middle-Power Diplomacy (The G20 Model):** India's successful **G20 Presidency (G20 Leaders' New Delhi Declaration)** proved that middle powers can bridge the divide between a fractured West and the Sino-Russian bloc, offering a template for consensus-building in polarized times.

Conclusion

As a champion of strategic autonomy and the voice of the Global South, India is uniquely positioned to act as a 'Vishwa Mitra' (Global Friend). By pushing for reformed multilateralism, New Delhi can help build an international legal order that is equitable, universally binding, and free from both Western hypocrisy and authoritarian manipulation.

> ***Drishti Mains Question:***
>
> What is meant by Authoritarian International Law? Analyse how the selective interpretation of sovereignty and international legal norms challenges the liberal international order.

Frequently asked questions (FAQs)

1. What is international law, and what are its principal sources?
International law governs relations among states and other recognised international actors. Under Article 38 of the ICJ Statute, its principal sources include treaties, international custom and general principles of law, with judicial decisions and scholarly writings serving as subsidiary means.

2. What is Authoritarian International Law?
It refers to the use or reinterpretation of international legal norms to prioritise regime survival, executive power and state sovereignty over individual rights, democratic accountability and external scrutiny.

3. What are the major challenges in preserving a fair international legal order?
Key challenges include the enforcement deficit, selective compliance by powerful states, populist nationalism, outdated global institutions and the unequal representation of developing countries in international decision-making.

4. What measures can strengthen international law and global accountability?
Key measures include UNSC reform, restraint in the use of vetoes during mass atrocities, stronger international dispute settlement, universal jurisdiction, equitable representation of the Global South and clearer rules for emerging technological domains.

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. With reference to the "United Nations Credentials Committee", consider the following statements: (2022)

1. It is a committee set up by the UN Security Council and works under its supervision.
2. It traditionally meets in March, June and September every year
3. It assesses the credentials of all UN members before submitting a report to the General Assembly for approval.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct? (2022)

(a) 3 only

(b) 1 and 3

(c) 2 and 3

(d) 1 and 2

Ans: (a)

Q. With reference to the United Nations, consider the following statements: (2009)

1. The Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) of the UN consists of 24 member States.
2. It is elected by a 2/3rd majority of the General Assembly for a 3-year term.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only

(b) 2 only

(c) Both 1 and 2

(d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. "With the waning of globalization, post-Cold War world is becoming a site of sovereign nationalism." Elucidate. **(2025)**

Q. What are the main functions of the United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)? Explain different functional commissions attached to it. **(2017)**

Q. Discuss the impediments India is facing in its pursuit of a permanent seat in the UN Security Council **(2015)**

Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana

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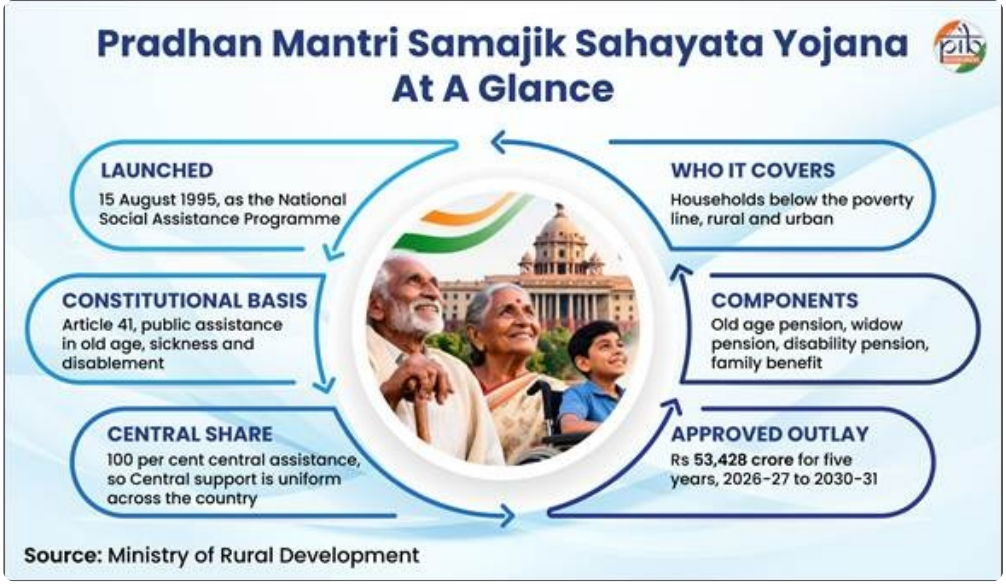
Source: PIB

Why in News?

Recently, the Union Cabinet approved the continuation and renaming of the **National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP)** as the **Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana** , along with revisions to the disability pension.

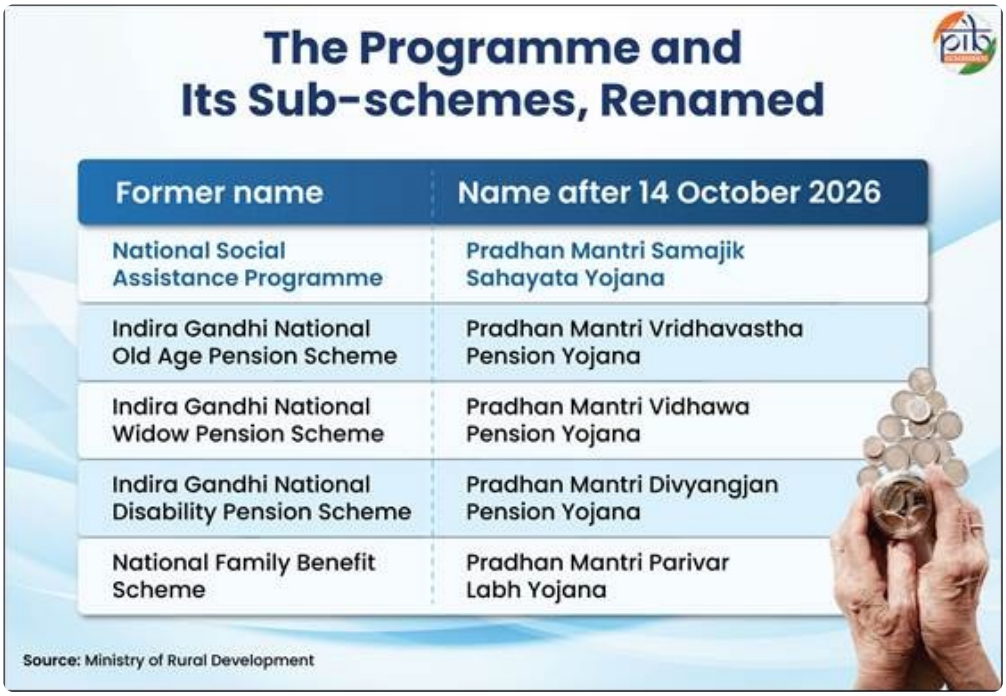
What are the Key Facts About Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana?

- **About:** Originally launched as the **National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) on 15th August 1995** , it provides financial assistance to **Below Poverty Line (BPL)** households facing old age, widowhood, disability or the death of a primary breadwinner.
- **Constitutional Basis:** Gives effect to **Article 41** under the **Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP),** which directs the State to provide public assistance in cases of unemployment, old age, sickness and disablement, within its economic capacity.
- **Nodal Ministry and Funding:** Implemented under the **Ministry of Rural Development as a 100% centrally funded Centrally Sponsored Scheme** , providing minimum financial assistance to **eligible beneficiaries in rural and urban areas** .
- **Implementation:** Implemented by States and Union Territories, with **Gram Panchayats and municipalities** assisting in beneficiary identification and payments largely facilitated through **Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT).**
- **Financial Outlay:** Approved allocation of **₹53,428 crore for five years (2026–2031), covering approximately 3.20 crore beneficiaries** across all 36 States and UTs.
- **State Supplementation:** States and UTs provide additional pension assistance above the Central contribution, with **top-ups ranging from ₹50 to ₹5,700** per month (September 2026), resulting in average monthly pensions of around ₹1,100 in several States/UTs.
- **Continuity:** The old-age pension, widow pension and family benefit schemes continue unchanged, while the disability pension has been revised in terms of eligibility, coverage and assistance rates.



Revised Components

The programme comprises **three monthly pension schemes and one lump-sum family benefit scheme** , all renamed under the revised framework:



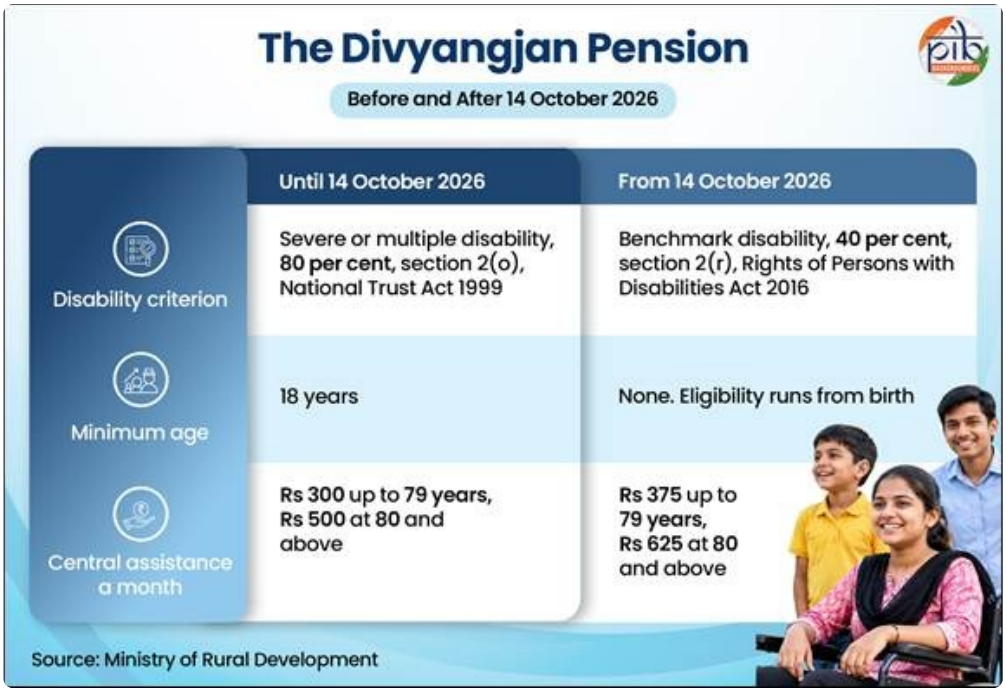
Significance

- **Inclusive Social Protection:** Extends financial assistance to persons with **40–79% disabilities, reducing exclusion under the earlier 80% eligibility threshold** .
- **Childhood Disability Support:** Removal of the minimum age requirement **enables early financial assistance to eligible children** with disabilities from BPL households.
- **Financial Security:** Enhanced pension rates strengthen basic income support for economically vulnerable persons with disabilities.
- **Cooperative Federalism:** Central assistance supplemented by State and UT contributions enables locally responsive social protection, while maintaining a common national minimum.

What are the Key Reforms under Pradhan Mantri

Divyangjan Pension Yojana?

- **Background:** Introduced in **February 2009 as the Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme,** it originally provided **pensions to Below Poverty Line (BPL) persons** aged 18 years and above with at least 80% disability.
- **Legal Basis:** The revisions align the scheme with the **Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 ,** enacted to give effect to the **UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD)** .
  - **Section 2(r) of the Act** defines a person with a benchmark disability as someone with at least 40% of a specified disability, as certified by the competent authority.
- **Revised Eligibility:** The minimum disability requirement has been reduced from 80% to 40%, while the minimum age of 18 years has been removed, extending eligibility from birth.
- **Enhanced Pension:** Monthly Central assistance has been increased by 25%:
  - Below 80 years: Increased from ₹300 to ₹375 per month.
  - 80 years and above: Increased from ₹500 to ₹625 per month.
- **Expanded Coverage:** The number of beneficiaries has been increased from 8.33 lakh to 27.48 lakh.
- **Implementation:** Revised guidelines covering eligibility, beneficiary numbers and assistance rates are to be issued and implemented within three months of the Cabinet's approval.



Conclusion

The Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana strengthens India's social security framework through expanded disability coverage, enhanced financial assistance and continued support for vulnerable households. Aligning disability pensions with the **Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016** represents an important step towards inclusive, rights-based and accessible social protection.

Drishti Mains Practice Question

The expansion of disability pension coverage under Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana marks a shift towards more inclusive social protection in India. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. What is Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana?
It is the renamed National Social Assistance Programme, providing financial assistance to eligible BPL households affected by old age, widowhood, disability or the death of a primary breadwinner.

Q2. What is the approved financial outlay for the scheme?
The Union Cabinet approved ₹53,428 crore for the period 2026–27 to 2030–31.

Q3. What is the revised disability eligibility criterion?
The minimum disability threshold has been reduced from 80% to 40% benchmark disability, with the earlier minimum age requirement of 18 years removed.

Q4. What are the revised pension amounts under Pradhan Mantri Divyangjan Pension Yojana?
The Central pension assistance is ₹375 monthly for ages 0–79 years and ₹625 monthly for beneficiaries aged 80 years and above.

Q5. Which constitutional provision forms the basis of the scheme?
Article 41, under the Directive Principles of State Policy, provides for public assistance in cases such as old age, sickness and disablement.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/SAA9j5tzlDw]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Which of the following statements with regard to the persons with disabilities in India is/are correct? (2026)

1. The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, an Act passed by the Parliament of India in 2018, mandates reservation in education and employment, places a legal duty on Governments to ensure accessibility and non-discrimination.
2. The Sugamya Bharat Abhiyan focuses on achieving universal accessibility for Persons with Disabilities across three key domains -built infrastructure, transport systems and information and communication technology.
3. The National Divyangjan Finance and Development Corporation (NDFDC) is a public sector organisation set up by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs as a not-for-profit company to promote entrepreneurship among Persons with Disabilities (PwDs).

Select the answer using the code given below:

(a) 1 and 2

(b) 2 only

(c) 1 and 3

(d) 1 only

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 remains only a legal document without intense sensitisation of government functionaries and citizens regarding disability. Comment. **(2022)**

Singapore-India Maritime Bilateral Exercise (SIMBEX) 2026

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Source: PIB

Recently, the **33 rd edition of the Singapore-India Maritime Bilateral Exercise (SIMBEX-2026)** commenced at **Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh** , with the participation of the **Republic of Singapore Navy (RSN) ship RSS Supreme.**

- **Origin:** Initiated in 1994 as **Exercise Lion King** , SIMBEX is one of the Indian Navy's **longest-running bilateral maritime exercises,** conducted annually without interruption, including during the COVID-19 pandemic through modified formats.
- **Objective:** The exercise aims to enhance operational interoperability, professional cooperation and mutual understanding between the two navies.
- **Harbour Phase:** Involves professional interactions, **Subject Matter Expert Exchanges (SMEEs), cross-deck visits, sporting engagements** and **planning conferences.**
- **Sea Phase:** Conducted in the **Bay of Bengal ,** featuring **anti-submarine warfare (ASW) , anti-surface and anti-air warfare drills, seamanship evolutions and tactical manoeuvres.**
- **Significance** : SIMBEX strengthens **India-Singapore defence cooperation, operational interoperability and mutual understanding** , while supporting efforts to address common maritime security challenges and promote **peace and stability in the Indo-Pacific region** .



Read more: **INS Tarkash Participates in IBSAMAR IX 2026**

India's Highest High Court Bench Inaugurated in Leh

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Source: IE

Chief Justice of India (CJI) inaugurated the **permanent Ladakh Bench of the Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh High Court** in Leh, at an altitude of approximately **3,500 metres** , making it **India's highest-altitude High Court bench** .

- **Establishment:** The bench was established under the **Union Territory of Ladakh (Sitting of Bench of the High Court of Jammu and Kashmir, and Ladakh in Ladakh) Regulation, 2026,** promulgated by the **President under Article 240 of the Constitution and Section 58(2) of the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act, 2019** .
- **Jurisdiction:** It functions as a **permanent bench of the Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh High Court** , providing judicial access to litigants in the Union Territory of Ladakh.
  - Under the **Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act, 2019** , the erstwhile Jammu and Kashmir High Court became the **common High Court for the two Union Territories** .
- **Digital Access:** The inaugural proceedings adopted a **hybrid hearing model** , while the Supreme Court plans to facilitate video conferencing for Ladakh-related cases, reducing travel requirements for litigants and lawyers.
- **Significance:** Strengthens access to justice, judicial decentralisation and **affordable legal services** in the geographically remote Himalayan region, while encouraging greater participation of Ladakh's youth in the legal profession.

Read More: High Court of Jammu and Kashmir Bench to Sit in Ladakh

Bharat Pavilion Showcases Indian Water Technologies at WETEX 2026

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Source: AIR

Recently, Indian companies showcased indigenous water treatment, environmental and sustainability technologies at the Water, Energy, Technology and Environment Exhibition (WETEX) 2026, held at the **Dubai World Trade Centre, UAE** .

- **About WETEX:** The **28th edition of a major international exhibition** organised by the **Dubai Electricity and Water Authority (DEWA),** focusing on water, energy, technology and environmental sustainability.
- **Bharat Pavilion:** Organised by the **Services Export Promotion Council (SEPC) under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry** , Government of India, to promote Indian services exports and strengthen international business partnerships.
- **Technologies Showcased:**
  - **Water Management:** Water treatment plants, sewage treatment systems, membranes, pumps and filtration technologies.
  - **Advanced Technologies:** Underwater robots, artificial intelligence (AI)-powered facility intelligence systems and indigenous water quality monitoring solutions.
  - **Environmental Solutions:** Bioculture, odour control, automation and sustainable industrial processes.
- **Export Promotion Mission :** Supported eligible Indian exhibitors with assistance towards exhibition participation costs, facilitating their entry into international markets.
- **Business Opportunities:** Enabled Indian companies to explore distribution agreements, joint ventures, technology partnerships and project collaborations with global industry participants.
- **Significance:** Highlights India's growing capabilities in **Make in India water technologies** , promotes services exports, and strengthens India–UAE economic cooperation in sustainable infrastructure and environmental solutions.

Read More: **Export Promotion Mission**

IISER Develops Solid Material for Hydrogen and Methane Production

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Source: TH

Researchers at the **Indian Institute of Science Education and Research (IISER), Thiruvananthapuram** , developed a solid compound that releases **hydrogen and methane** when heated.

- The compound, called **magnesium hydridomethylzincate** , is made of **magnesium, zinc, hydrogen and carbon** and remains solid at room temperature.
  - **Why It Matters:** Hydrogen is difficult and costly to store because of its **very low density** . A solid material could provide **an alternative to transporting fuel gases in compressed form** .
  - **Limitation:** The material is **highly sensitive to moisture** , and researchers have not yet shown whether it can be **recharged with gases after use** .
- **About Methane: Methane** is the simplest hydrocarbon and the **first member of the alkane series,** consisting of one carbon atom bonded to four hydrogen atoms.
  - It is a colourless, odourless, **highly flammable gas** , **lighter than air,** and is the **main constituent of natural gas.**
  - It is found in **underground natural gas deposits** and is produced through the decomposition of organic matter in oxygen-deficient environments.
  - It is widely used as a fuel for **cooking, heating and electricity generation** and as a raw material for producing hydrogen, methanol and other chemicals.
- **About Hydrogen: Hydrogen** is the lightest and most abundant chemical element in the universe.
  - It is a colourless, odourless, tasteless and **highly flammable gas** .
  - It is **found in water (H_2O)** , organic compounds and stars, but rarely occurs in its free form on Earth.
  - It is used in **ammonia production** , petroleum refining, **rocket fuel** and hydrogen fuel cells.
  - **Green Hydrogen** is produced by **splitting water through electrolysis using renewable energy sources,** it offers a low-emission alternative to hydrogen produced from fossil fuels.

Read More : **Green Hydrogen**